notes from underground existentialist philosphy literature philosophy guy transcript

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Intro

0:04 | we're going to look now at Dostoyevky's Notes From The Underground and this is a
0:10 | classic piece of existential literature it's kind of a hybrid between uh a
0:16 | confession a philos philosophical treaties and a short story written from
0:22 | the firsters perspective um it's been very influential on the development of of
0:29 | later existential thought get cited quite often and it's even had some importance outside of existentialism per
0:36 | se particularly because of some of the Striking images uh like the Crystal
0:43 | Palace that that are um worked out in in this this
0:48 | piece so why is it though an important existentialist text

0:55 | um that's worth reflecting on before we dig into it
1:02 | is this a representation of the existentialist stance towards the self towards the
1:10 | world towards reality towards emotions towards rationality
1:16 | towards culture and Society um towards relations between
1:25 | people yes and no I I don't think that you can actually
1:31 | say that there's one single existentialist stance this is a point
1:37 | that that various writers have made in in within the existentialist movement in
1:43 | talking about the existentialist movement it it doesn't seem possible to pin everything down very neatly uh and
1:52 | to say here is the one example already in the beginning you know we have kard
1:57 | Dostoesky and Niche as these seminal figures and they're they're quite different from each
2:02 | other um is it then a typical existentialist
2:08 | stance it is a typical existentialist stance we're going to see not necessarily the one single one but a
2:16 | typical stance and that's part of why it's got the importance that it does um like I said some of the other importance
2:22 | stems from its stock of images like the Crystal Palace that we'll look at later one of the things that I think we
2:29 | have to ask at the beginning that's going to run through this entirely and which the character himself is in some
2:36 | ways trying to work out is who is this underground man who is this character
2:42 | who is this this narrative who is this person and one thing that I want to caution you about right from the start
2:50 | is identifying the underground man with dooi
2:55 | himself um sometimes this this takes place um it's important to see that that
3:01 | the character is not necessarily the um author character is not necessarily just
3:08 | a mouthpiece for for the author uh a similar mistake gets made by
3:14 | people who only read Alber camuz The Stranger and they assume that the um
3:20 | stance the attitudes the sentiments the ideas of the main character in that
3:27 | piece Express who kamu is his views are on things um with doses get a little bit
3:34 | harder to pin down part of his genius seems to have been actually Spinning Out characters
3:41 | who who represent coherent perspectives but are but are not necessarily him and putting
3:47 | them into play with each other and working out sort of ethical moral uh existential
3:54 | dilemas um so we don't want to we don't want to identify those you very clearly

Literary Fiction

4:01 | with this so what's he doing he is exploring the self in human nature through a
4:07 | particular person a kind of type um not necessarily Humanity as such
4:13 | he's not saying this one guy is the image of all human beings or even the
4:19 | most authentic human being um he frames things and this is
4:24 | where we can ask is if the character isn't doeski himself
4:30 | is this just a literary fiction is just just like him playing around with things
4:35 | and dovi um tells us a few things not much but
4:41 | just a very few things there is a footnote where
4:49 | um doeski as the author writes it goes without saying that both these notes and
4:55 | their author are fictitious nevertheless people like the author Au of these notes May and indeed must exist in our society
5:03 | if we think of the circumstances under which that Society has been formed it's been my wish to show the public a
5:09 | character of the recent past more clearly than is usually shown he belongs to the generation that is now rounding
5:15 | out its days in the exerpt entitled The mouseful this man introduces himself and presents his views trying to explain why

5:22 | he is appeared and could not help it appear in our midst the next exerpt consists of this man's actual notes
5:28 | relating to certain events in his life so he he's adopting this this literary
5:34 | fiction uh this literary device of um saying I found you know he's not saying
5:40 | I found these notes um and I'm replicating them but something like this
5:46 | ought to be the case in a way reminds me a little bit of thiddies uh if you if youve read FUSD
5:54 | the great Greek historian he recounts a lot of speeches
6:01 | one of the things that he says about his his uh you might say process of
6:07 | quotation is I'm not actually giving you these speeches verbatim exactly as they were said I'm giving you sometimes what
6:14 | the characters ought to have said given the kind of person who they
6:20 | were um so cron may not have actually said the things that he that FUSD says
6:26 | that he reports that he said but he said like it and he said something along
6:32 | those lines because Kanon was the kind of guy to do that at the very end Doki
6:39 | also tells us um this is kind of interesting he
6:47 | says actually the notes of this lover of paradoxes do not end here he couldn't
6:52 | resist him went on writing but we are of the opinion that one might just as well stop here so
6:58 | dooi um he's doing something very interesting here he's saying well the writer of
7:06 | these notes and now now he's not saying oh yeah this is the kind of thing that I'm making up because you know it would
7:12 | have come on the scene now he's actually presenting it as if I do have these notes in front of me
7:18 | and I'm I'm just copying them for you the reader and he says they they keep going on and on and on um they should
7:25 | have stopped here because the the person says that's enough I've had enough of writing these Notes From The Underground
7:30 | that's the last thing from the underground me to say
7:40 | um the notes themselves the genre if you had to pick
7:45 | a genra that it fits closest to is a confession and the the writer actually
7:51 | brings this up a couple times he says I'm trying to put matters down I'm trying to make sense of them I'm trying
7:58 | to R he doesn't say wrap my head around them but but that's the sort of way we would talk about it now um he talks
8:04 | about these as being admissions um
8:11 | and here we go he

Every decent man has an accumulation

8:17 | says I've taken a fancy into my head and I want to realize at any cost I've got a
8:22 | whim and I'm going to follow that through what I mean is there are things
8:27 | in every man's past that he won't admit except to his most intimate friends there are other things that he
8:33 | won't admit even to his friends but only to himself and only in strictest confidence but there are things too a
8:40 | man won't dare to admit even to himself and every decent man has quite an accumulation of such
8:47 | things in fact the more decent he is the greater the accumulation he's bound to
8:53 | have I have only recently dared to explore some of my past Adventures which until then I had avoided with with
9:00 | peculiar anxiety but now that I have made myself remember them and even dared to write them down I want to make a test
9:07 | to see whether it is possible to be to be completely Frank and unafraid of the
9:13 | whole truth I would like to note here as Hines remarked to the the effect that sincere
9:19 | autobiographies are almost impossible and a man is bound to lie about himself
9:24 | I'm sure Hana is right but Hana was passing judgement on man confessing publicly now in my case

9:32 | I'm writing this just for myself for even if I do address myself to imaginary
9:37 | readers I do it only because it makes it easier for me to write it's a matter of form nothing else for as I said before
9:45 | I'll never have any readers

Expecting the reader

9:50 | so there's a lot of paradoxes involved here aren't there um and we don't have
9:56 | to explore those in in great depth it's worth pointing them out is doeski
10:02 | expecting a reader for this is is the guy who's actually talking expecting a reader he's addressing readers but now
10:08 | it looks as if he's doing that just so he can kind of pull the truth out of himself and so that's one Paradox the
10:16 | other one is it consists in a
10:22 | word he says unafraid unafraid of the whole
10:28 | truth so what's one of the most common aects
10:33 | that you see running through this this story
10:39 | fear anxiety fear of all sorts of things
10:44 | along with that cowardice and courage so this guy
10:51 | by laying out on paper his moments of cowardice is being unafraid is that yet
10:58 | another way of trying to sort of console himself and make him feel like he's not a coward when he really is a
11:04 | coward or is there a greater sense of Courage here that trumps other
11:12 | Courage the kind of Courage that we tend to respect and look at as being instances of of the
11:19 | type but wouldn't that be very much along the lines that you could expect
11:25 | that a bitter impotent intellectual who's disdainful of people
11:31 | of action and spontaneity might say as a response to try to elevate
11:38 | their own kind of Courage over that of others it's sort of like the well I'm
11:43 | less of a hypocrite because I confess that I'm a hypocrite and we're all
11:49 | Hypocrites there's you know on the one hand a sort of Ring Of Truth to that and on the other hand sort of a tone of
11:55 | insincerity so again another another paradox um let's talk now about
12:04 | um we'll go back to who this guy is but talk about how Doki put this together since we're talking about literary
12:11 | composition there's two parts to this if we if we take out the The Narrative framing that dooi himself is putting in
12:17 | with these little you know notes at the beginning and end the first part is the mouse hole and that is it starts out as
12:25 | seeming to be the kind of rambling andoun who he is and then it starts to
12:31 | get more and more and more philosophical and eventually reaches a peak of of
12:38 | essentially being something like a philosophical treaties still addressed to a reader however so there's a
12:44 | dialectical or dialogical element to it there's that and then this the entire
12:49 | second half is a story about how this guy you know um got
12:58 | involved in these as he call calls them adventures during the course of which he borrows some money um meets up with some
13:06 | old school acquaintances goes to a dinner with them um neglects to pay his
13:12 | uh his servant for the time being um makes an ass of himself at dinner for
13:20 | reasons that we can talk about later um goes off to a a brothel meets a
13:27 | prostitute um has a long conversation with her gives
13:33 | her his address leaves um has a few days pass and then
13:41 | she comes to his place and they have another interaction um which turns out in large
13:50 | respect quite badly for for both of them those are the sort of things that

13:56 | he's talking about that's the the uh how did he put it
14:06 | um things that that a person won't even admit to his friends uh or to
14:12 | himself um every decent man is quite an accumulation of such things and these
14:18 | are his past Adventures which he had avoided with with peculiar anxiety he doesn't want to think about these things
14:23 | and what it what it says about himself and the pointlessness or um failure of
14:30 | of what he's doing and the way that he's living so all that said let's go back to

Who is this guy

14:36 | this who who is this guy what does he tell us about himself there is some biography in this it's all autobiography
14:42 | um I'm not sure exactly how much we ought to trust it but all we have to go on is is what he gives us um so we can
14:50 | ask about his biography the the facts about him and then we can ask about his his character what do we know he's an
14:57 | orphan we know that he talks about growing up without parents um he went to
15:04 | school um there he met a lot of people he seems to have excelled
15:10 | in uh what we might call abstract or Scholastic kind of studies and was
15:16 | singled out uh then he entered government service he actually entered it in order to make a living uh and then
15:24 | transferred from one Department to another he says so he could get away from his for
15:30 | schoolmates um so he's a kind of he's a guy who and this goes from biography to character he's a kind of guy who leaves
15:36 | things behind you might say unfinished um he works as a government
15:43 | employee for for a while as a a clerk and then after he receives a small
15:48 | inheritance he quits and he moves to an apartment
15:55 | um in the city of of Peters B where he was located before um he really can't afford it that
16:04 | well he has to scrape by uh he could live in a place that's cheaper but he chooses to live in in in Petersburg in a
16:10 | not so great area of town and um he essentially lives on on this this
16:18 | inheritance so he doesn't really do much of anything at that point um he talks of his office head
16:27 | Anton an is his only
16:32 | acquaintance um and he is a pretty isolated man it's it's it's not really correct to say that
16:40 | that's his only acquaintance because if we look at the story he runs across other people who he knows he remembers
16:47 | from school um he also has a servant who he doesn't he doesn't get along with
16:52 | very well quite frankly um his servant doesn't appear to be a particularly good type either but it would be hard to work
16:59 | for a guy like this so I can I can just imagine you know what the interactions would be like uh he he's pretty isolated
17:07 | he's a thinker he's an intellectual uh he's not extremely
17:12 | practical but he he is able to get quite a few things done um he's able to borrow
17:17 | money from people for one thing he manages to keep things more or less
17:22 | straight so he's not just a dreamer in his head in the clouds um but like he says his action is
17:29 | infected with ideas and one of the things that I think is really telling about that goes to
17:37 | character he he is an intellectual he can't stop thinking he thinks too much

Intellectual

17:46 | in the wrong ways he he engages in reflection that doesn't generate an
17:52 | awful lot of understanding um it's it's as if no matter what you say to the guy he's
17:58 | always got got one more thing to to say that's being suggested to him that's popping into his head

18:07 | um but there's an insecurity there about his capacity to think not only you know
18:15 | a sense of futility like what the hell is all this for you know other people seem to be succeeding quite quite better
18:21 | than me um and being an intellectual does not seem to make you particularly happy compared to being a person of
18:28 | action but he actually seems to be um very
18:34 | concerned that other people think of him as an intellectual so here's a
18:42 | great he's uh going into to an office and he says let my face be plain I
18:47 | thought as long as it's dignified expressive and above all incredibly
18:53 | intelligent I was painfully aware however that my facial expression could not possibly con all these qualities and
19:00 | worse yet while I'd have settled for anything as long as it looked intelligent I found my face positively
19:07 | stupid I'd have even accepted a depraved expression if at the same time everyone had agreed everyone had agreed I love
19:14 | that line that I had a terribly intelligent face so this is a guy who
19:21 | who he is an intellectual he is a thinker he he can't escape that he does have
19:27 | talent but he wants other people people that he he seems not to
19:32 | care at all about he wants other people to think of him not only as intelligent
19:37 | but as terribly intelligent and as that even being written on his
19:43 | face so there there is a fundamental insecurity there I think um something
19:50 | that can't possibly be satisfied right so he says that uh and again this goes

Character

19:56 | to his his character he says says he's really painfully sensitive and complex
20:02 | as a man of this age should be um what does he mean by this age he means an age
20:08 | which is becoming enlightened in which um people are no longer uh relating to
20:15 | each other just in terms of feudal relations or economic relations or
20:22 | during war time I mean Russia gone through some some pretty tough times uh
20:28 | you know half a century before um but they're relating to each other in
20:35 | in other ways the world of the mind has penetrated the other world so to speak
20:45 | um he lacks a stable sense of who or what he is he lacks persistence or
20:52 | perseverance or consistency he talks about this in terms of not being able to
20:58 | stick to things and yet not even being lazy in the sense of being able to say
21:04 | that guy is a lazy guy and being able to say now I know what he is who he is
21:10 | um so this is this is a real problem for for him
21:18 | um he says
21:25 | uh he's never able to even follow through on Revenge um and he gives some examples of
21:33 | that so he's also capable of decent human
21:40 | interactions and he doesn't do that he does do them sometimes but he can't be
21:46 | relied upon to continue doing them he can't be relied upon to consistently
21:52 | behave like a decent human being um so every once in a while he'll
21:57 | just say something cruel biting you know for instance when he's at the uh retirement dinner for for
22:05 | his friend well not his friend that his acquaintance from from school and he throws in there a Barb about you know
22:12 | this person of course this person who's retiring he's talking about how what a great guy he is he's doing lots of name
22:18 | dropping and so the underground man says yeah how come so and so didn't come to
22:23 | your party and it's it's not just committing a full ha there's a maliciousness
22:31 | involved but not a maliciousness like man I'm going to get that guy all right here comes my chance now I got him more
22:38 | like oh there's a chance to do something mean all right I'll do it
22:44 | so that's a that's that's part of his character what are his typical moods um we're going to talk a

little
22:52 | bit more about about this and different a effects later but let's note right now
22:57 | that part of his character central part of his character the moods that you see him talking about the most are on two
23:04 | different ends one is fear uh anxiety uh concern about what people are
23:11 | going to think and perhaps a sense of Shame the other is resentment
23:19 | irritation uh maliciousness
23:24 | um these are these are most of his his his range of feelings he does also talk
23:30 | about Joy he also talks about desire um but the two main stars in the
23:38 | constellation are I think anger and fear
23:44 | um he makes some remarks about about reading that are somewhat relevant um
23:52 | about dissolution and uh we're going to look at that in just a moment he also also
23:58 | talks about about love and so here we're focusing on his character
24:05 | and there are certain passages that are that are very revealing so let's look at why reading is so important to this
24:11 | kindy I mean you could understand for an intellectual reading would be at the center of who he is but there are
24:17 | different ways of reading um the spiritual reading that a monk does um each
24:24 | day Lao deina is something very different than the kind of reading that he's doing the reading that somebody
24:32 | does to study to pass the bar exam after going through
24:37 | law school is very different than the kind of reading that that he's talking about um so he says at home I mostly
24:44 | read I had to drown out the clam with in me and reading was the only available
24:49 | way so there's a clamor inside of him there's a there's a dis Qui a
24:55 | restlessness inside of him and reading is way to take care of that and I think we know a lot of people maybe some of us
25:03 | are like that ourselves at times who read to escape um and so long as we can fix our
25:11 | our minds on somebody else's story some other issue we are LED away from looking at
25:20 | ourselves and our own termoil and trials and failures
25:26 | and um missed opportunities and regrets and things like
25:32 | that so says reading of course was helpful it stirred delight and tormented me now and then however I grew terribly
25:40 | tired of it I became restless and plunged not into real debauchery but
25:45 | into murky sorted Petty dissipation my Petty passion stabbed and
25:50 | burn me because I was already on edge I suffered hysterical outbursts of tears and
25:56 | convulsions um so this is a guy who breaks down every so often by himself in
26:02 | his in his apartment you know he does actually have a crying Jag in the arms of the The Prostitute later on in the
26:09 | story but that doesn't seem to be typically what happens
26:16 | um not into real debauchery he doesn't count going to the to the whouse as real
26:21 | debauchery uh although he you can tell he does that from time to time because he talks about when he goes to the
26:27 | brothel um this being a place that that he knows already uh but in a murky sort
26:33 | of petty dissipation aside from my reading I had nothing to turn to for there was nothing
26:40 | in my surroundings that I could look up to or that attracted me I was sick of everything and long to contradict and
26:47 | oppose long to contradict and oppose that's another key element of who this
26:54 | guy is um and and it leads to what his biography the back to him because the
26:59 | fact is he he says things to people to tick them off or to to you know show them that he's not you know seeing
27:06 | things the same way as them or that he has some power over them or they're not going to make him do things their way
27:15 | um we'll see why in a little while why that that's such a strong urge in him

27:22 | so it says I abandon myself to dissipation um I indulged in Vice at

Vices

27:29 | night steadily fearfully sorted the feeling of Shame was always present and
27:35 | in the most unspeakable moments it was like damnation itself even then I carry
27:40 | this hole in the floor of my heart that's a beautiful expression isn't it of an ugly thing even then it carried
27:48 | this hole in the floor of my heart I was terribly afraid to be seen and recognized and I went to the lowest
27:54 | haunts so he did engage in some some Vice what were his vices
27:59 | you know probably the typical things that that people do um drinking you know
28:05 | to excess um getting into arguments talking you
28:11 | know uh just for the sake of talking gossiping um lying to
28:18 | people uh pickups one night stands those sorts of things he actually gives us
28:24 | this this funny incident once passing by a Tavern I I saw fighting with bilard cues through a lighted window one of
28:30 | them was tossed out with the window I envied the ejected gentleman so much I entered the tavern and stepped
28:36 | into the bliard room thinking maybe I could pick a fight to and be thrown out the window um and then he talks about this
28:43 | this whole thing with this officer who uh treats him like an object um
28:50 | but what else is going on so he um he's going to talk about reading some more
28:56 | later on reading is an escape for him from his life in which he's not entirely
29:02 | inactive he is actually out there pursuing these sort of petty sort of Pleasures um What About
29:10 | Love well that's where we get back to reading again reading and
29:18 | dreaming he says that um he resigned himself sometimes I had an escape that
29:25 | made everything bearable I took refuge in the Sublime and the Beautiful In My Dreams of
29:31 | course um I gave myself over entirely to Dreaming dreaming away for three months
29:38 | and end huddled in my corner and believe me in my dreams I had nothing in common with with who who I am right
29:46 | um my dreams were sweeter and stronger after my Petty dissipations and were
29:51 | accompanied by remorse tears cursing and ecstasy I experience moments of actual
29:57 | intoxication and I swear was happy without finding it in the least ridiculous that's a strange
30:03 | thing to say too to be happy without finding your happiness ridiculous this is a man who is in some respect afraid
30:12 | of Happiness isn't it I had faith hope love the three theological virtues right
30:18 | so what are we talking about here part of this is he he's a guy who you know does these
30:25 | these small sins these small faults and then afterwards in his dreams you know
30:30 | arranges them into some sort of narrative uh presumably of like repentance and conversion and um you
30:37 | know we can well imagine him like you know conversing with angels and Saints in these dreams and expecting you know
30:44 | God to say uh you are you know on the right side finally I've been
30:51 | searching for you all those sorts of images right
30:56 | um that's just it I had Blind Faith That by some miracle some force would push
31:02 | aside the confining screen opening up a wide Horizon on which would be a worthwhile life work useful and Sublime
31:10 | and above all all cut out and waiting for me I didn't know what kind of work
31:15 | it should be but it was essential that it should be there ready and waiting for me to perform
31:21 | it now that's a really interesting thing to go to go from you know these sort of
31:27 | religious um views and all that which you know if you're really being religious humility
31:34 | is Central to that and part of humility is being able to say I go where I have to because uh you know

that's where God
31:41 | wants me and um I'm really not that important um what does he dream about he
31:48 | dreams about being important he dreams about having Things fall into place
31:53 | about like it say Horizons opening up and a task being set out for me that is
32:00 | mine and mine alone my purpose uh that which will make me be someone who
32:07 | matters who's able to step in and and do those sorts of things um useful and
32:14 | Sublime useful for other people and yet Sublime elevated Noble um could be to to
32:21 | fall in love with somebody to to make their life wonderful it could be to you
32:28 | know engage in some sort of magnificent gestures it could be to save the nation
32:36 | through U policing the streets or routing the enemy or it could be any
32:42 | sort of thing like that could be a victory in the life of the mind like he says
32:51 | um I couldn't even conceive of being second best that's why in real life I resigned myself so easily to being last
32:59 | if he can't have the top then screw it all and you've seen people like this right the more and more that we recount
33:05 | this person the less and less this seems like just a literary invention on doki's part uh I had to be either a hero or
33:13 | wallow in the mud and that's what turned out to be my undoing for while wallowing in the mud I'd console myself that at
33:18 | other times I was a hero that made it all right so this is a way of Escape for him
33:25 | again and again he says um it's noteworthy I
33:31 | usually thought of the sublime and the Beautiful during my dissipation often just when I hit the rock bottom of of
33:37 | objection then these thoughts came in little flashes as if to remind me of the existence of the sublime and the
33:42 | Beautiful but they didn't interfere with my dissipation just the opposite in fact they seem to spice it up by contrast and
33:48 | like a good sauce help to bring out the taste so I mean like right while he's doing bad things he's thinking to
33:54 | himself these these uh these dreams the sauce concocted of contradictions and
34:00 | suffering contain painful self-analysis and the resulting agonies and torments added piany and even meaning to my
34:07 | dissipation in short it was what a good SAU is meant to be there was more to it
34:12 | though for without the SLU I could hardly have born the Primitive vulgar uncomplicated dissipation of a petty
34:18 | government employee and the soil feeling that had left could any viice have drawn me into
34:24 | the street at night otherwise no but then I have the s so it's it's interesting he's claiming
34:30 | that because he's got these these moments of dreaming and thinking of himself as being this imaginary hero and
34:36 | that things are going to open up for him that somehow that's what enables him that doesn't just help him get him
34:42 | through the day that's what actually enables him to go out at night and and get drunk and get laid because otherwise
34:48 | he wouldn't maybe have the heart for that um now we get to another very
34:54 | important Point how much love I experienced in my
35:00 | dreams when I escaped to the sublime and beautiful perhaps it was an imaginary
35:05 | love and maybe it was never directed toward another human being but it was such an overflowing love there was no
35:11 | need to direct it that would have been an unnecessary luxury so he feels this this affect of
35:18 | love and it's not for anything in particular it's just a sense of love and
35:24 | to single in on any one thing say would have been a luxury everything always ended safely in
35:30 | a leisurely Rapture Rapture sliding into the domain of art that is into the beautiful lives of Heroes stolen from
35:36 | them authors of novels and poems and adapted to the demands of the moment whatever they might

be I for instance
35:43 | triumph over everyone and they are of course strewn in the dust acknowledging my superiority I'm all forgiving I'm a
35:50 | great poet in court Chamberlain I fall in love I inherit millions and donate them to human causes and take advantage
35:56 | of this opportunity to publicly confess my backslidings and disgrace which of course is no ordinary disgrace but
36:03 | contains much that is Sublime and beautiful in it everyone is weeping and kissing me that I leave hungry and
36:09 | Barefoot to preach new ideas and Route the reactionaries at aets um so again these grandiose ideas
36:19 | about what he's going to do and and it's interesting you notice that okay I'm talking about love and and I feel this
36:26 | love for every body and it's reaching out towards everything and then very quickly it starts to become about the
36:31 | self and it's less about my expression of love for for these other people it's
36:37 | more about how they love me I'm such a lovable person and that's really what
36:43 | this guy is is lacking at his at his heart um he does not feel in any sense
36:55 | loved his own sense of love what love consists in is
37:02 | um well

Love

37:09 | um it's very problematic to say the least let me read you a
37:15 | passage um he sees a person who he actually loves in in this prostitute
37:20 | when he breaks down himself um he goes into this long speech about
37:27 | her where he's he's essentially rejecting her on every different level and he says at this point a very strange
37:34 | thing happened I was so used to imagining everything happening the way it does in books I didn't pay attention to what was
37:40 | going on what actually happened was that Liza who I had humiliated and
37:46 | crushed understood much more than I had thought out of all that that I had said
37:51 | she had understood what a sincerely loving woman would understand first that I myself was unhappy
38:00 | notice he's able to to see her as a sincerely loving woman because
38:07 | of her action towards him so it's not as if he's totally blind to what love consists
38:13 | in but what shape can love take for him as he's he's giving it to other
38:20 | people um he says
38:27 | I couldn't fall in love because for me loving means bullying and
38:33 | dominating I have never been able to imagine any other way of loving and have reached a point where to me love
38:40 | consists of a voluntary concession by the object of my love of my right to bully it even dreaming in my mouthful i'
38:48 | never visualized love as anything but a struggle starting with hatred and ending in the subjection of the loved object
38:56 | after which I was unable to to think of anything so this is this is love as
39:01 | desire it's not even desire to to it's not even Heros like the desire to have
39:07 | sex or the desire to you know uh you know more contemplative to just be in
39:12 | the same presence of the person for him to love means to to dominate to bully
39:18 | and um he can tell that that things are going well with him when the loved object permits him to to bully you um
39:26 | this actually reminds me of an earlier passage where he talks about having a
39:32 | um acquaintance in school he was not liked by most of the other kids but he was liked by another kid

Integration

39:41 | until he bullied him and he told him that it had to be uh either him and this
39:47 | other kid against everyone else or nothing that was you know a chance for
39:53 | him to do something different and what's interesting particularly interesting about this he's able to recognize that's
40:01 | not all there is to love but that's all there is to love for
40:06 | him the the key issue that we've been moving towards here the the Central
40:11 | Point around which all of this terms is that there's a disconnect for
40:16 | the underground man as as for all of us but it's the way that he handles it that matter there's a disconnect between how
40:23 | things are ideally how they ought to be how they're represented for example in
40:30 | books um in dreams in plans in our intentions and
40:35 | our hopes our aspirations and then how they actually turn out to be in reality and an integrated person is able not
40:43 | only to be integrated within themselves but to integrate those dreams hopes and all that with the reality there's two
40:50 | ways of not being integrated well when it comes to this two fundamental ways one is to give into reality and say hey
40:56 | that's the way it is Doggy Dog screw everyone I'm just going to be like these people over here figure out how to get
41:01 | along and all those hopes dreams and and indeed loges go out the window as being
41:08 | unrealistic that's to kill part of yourself and to kill actually the sublime and the Beautiful right a very
41:15 | good part of yourself that true maybe has to be you know um tempered to some
41:21 | degree and and we have to get to know through through books that are kind of misleading sometimes in our case movies
41:26 | and love and things like that the other way is to do with the underground man
41:31 | and to take refuge in this ideality which ends up being threadbear he's he's
41:37 | not the kind of idealist who believes his BS believes his ideology and you
41:44 | know makes reality conform to it to do that would be a man of action right he's one who wants that ideality
41:53 | to be reality can't make it so and hates
41:59 | reality as a result in response um now is this The Human

The Human Condition

42:09 | Condition um this is The Human Condition in many
42:16 | respects for many people what you can say about the underground man is he's not depicting
42:23 | The Human Condition as such for all human beings what he's rather showing
42:30 | you is a response that many people take to the problem of the relationship
42:38 | between this this realm of hopes dreams loves and the reality that does not
42:43 | conform to it and what happens when it's not integrated so um now let's talk about
42:52 | some of the more even philosophical meat uh having to do with reason
42:57 | passion desire and happiness practical rationality um there is this

Passion Desire

43:09 | long essentially di tribe carried out in dialogue against a Enlightenment
43:17 | scientific way of of seeing things um and so what's let's start with the
43:22 | starting problem um why does the good and the beau beautiful um the classic you know
43:30 | values not only of the Enlightenment but of philosophy
43:36 | literature um civilization in general why do they set us off the

43:41 | rails um he says the more conscious I was of the good and beautiful the deeper I sank into the mud the more likely I
43:47 | was to remain mired in it um that was my normal
43:54 | State um something no at my at me tore at myself and ate myself away until the
43:59 | bitterness turned into some shameful URS of swedishness and finally into a great unquestionable
44:05 | pleasure why is it that some people can actually take pleasure like he says in the blinding realization of my
44:13 | degradation um how can how can somebody find the ugly and the bad to be good and
44:20 | beautiful to be pleasant what's the explanation for this
44:26 | pleasure he says um he's got a discussion of Revenge and
44:34 | he talks about the man of action and the intellectuals response to
44:42 | situations of reveng why do we want rent well we feel like somebody has offended us somebody did something to us um they
44:48 | said something they hurt us in some way they overlooked
44:54 | us they treated us in a way that we didn't be Tre The Man of Action gets
44:59 | offended and then desires Revenge tries to take revenge if they can and they see

Revenge

45:05 | all of that as just right if they didn't see it as just or
45:12 | if somebody comes along and tells them that's not the right thing to do and they actually believe it then they say
45:18 | okay I guess I won't do it then uh that's what he talks about is like a stone wall you know if the Man of Action
45:26 | if you put a stone wall in front of him he just stops right there and now he's sort of content sort of like a horse or
45:32 | or a cow when you put up a fence they don't usually jump over the fence once they get used to it they're like fence
45:38 | there I'll go over here where there isn't offence you know um the
45:45 | intellectual wants to get revenge as well and they get offended even easier because they they
45:52 | have a much easier time taking offense right they're able to read into things so much easier
45:58 | um they'll even get offended at the other person not realizing that they offended the intellectual so how could
46:05 | you not know that that would be offensive to me um and again Boy you know you could think of a lot of people
46:12 | like that you know who who are just just ranous and surprised that you didn't
46:19 | know that this was offensive to them you know it seems like it changes every five years or so now you should not talk
46:25 | about this subject or use this word and they'll get so angry with you but they
46:30 | get angry with you uh and they will you know raise their voice and use words you
46:36 | know call you hateful and you know maybe shake their fist or something like that will they actually punch you out not
46:43 | really because they're not they're not men of action or women of action right real men and women of action they'll
46:49 | punch you out they don't like what you're saying they'll pop you in the face you know and then quite often you
46:56 | know think things can get worked out the intellectual just sort of lets it Fester there and they take indirect
47:04 | Revenge they wait until they can do it and they find little ways to be you know
47:09 | snide and sneaky and snarky and all that and here's where it's really
47:15 | interesting that's That's a classic contrast between open revenge and passive aggressive Revenge
47:22 | right like I said before the man of action for do here thinks that what he's
47:28 | doing is just he might be wrong about that but he feels that it's

47:35 | just the intellectual feels that it's not just
47:40 | that in some ways they're just as bad as the person who offended them and they find themselves doing something bad in
47:47 | the process to get revenge and that makes them feel even worse you know um this goes all the way
47:53 | back to Plato and you know the consciousness of Badness if a bad person
47:59 | actually realizes the Badness of their actions they're being punished already
48:04 | in that and they can't escape that um
48:10 | so nevertheless they keep on with all of it
48:15 | um like he says too when it comes to like you know the laws of nature or you
48:21 | know um stone walls or 2 plus 2 equal 4 The Man of Action stops short before
48:26 | that okay there's a wall the intellectual can't knock the wall down
48:32 | can't refute it but like he says won't accept it that's a key idea here the
48:39 | intellectual part of their reflective process is not to actually leap Beyond
48:44 | it in a heroic way um but to say I'm not going to accept it I don't like it I don't have
48:53 | to put up with it I don't have to agree with
48:59 | so let's look at this issue then of being rational recognizing as he says
49:04 | your your real interests um and the enlightenment

Being Rational

49:18 | idea or approach
49:27 | it focuses on being rational on on recognizing one's real interests as he
49:34 | says um there's a set of of you know arguments basically following from each
49:40 | other and he he lays out sort of a a caricature he
49:46 | says who was it that first said that man does nasty things only because he doesn't know where his real interests
49:52 | lie that if he were enlightened about his true interests he would immediately stop acting like a and become kind and
49:57 | Noble being Enlightenment the being enlightened the argument goes on and seeing where his real Advantage lie he
50:03 | would realize it was in acting virtuously and since it's well established a man will not act
50:08 | deliberately against his own interests it follows he would have no choice but to become
50:13 | good and that's that's pretty much it for the enlightenment right if you just knew
50:21 | what your real interests were and what it meant to be a you know good flourishing human being you'd knock off
50:28 | all your BS and immediately start working on yourself and try to be good and rational and maybe even pure and and
50:36 | make the rest of the world like that too so doeski brings up three problems
50:43 | with

Problems

50:49 | that problem one as he says do we at
51:01 | exclusively out of
51:12 | self-interest problem two
51:25 | is can you what actually is in the interest of a human
51:34 | being problem three
51:39 | is what is the interest is
51:47 | something something bad harmful
52:02 | ugly so these are three big problems I mean if if the enlightenment Viewpoint could actually take into account all of
52:09 | these things and somehow suck them in and chew them up and make sense to them and address them fully then it would be

52:15 | okay but it actually can't um and and so it's
52:22 | interesting um there's kind of a Seduction on the part of reason
52:28 | about how great reason is so Doki says this he
52:37 | says
52:46 | um here we go
52:54 | um all these lovely systems all these theories that explain a man what is to his true Advantage so that to achieve it
53:00 | he will for with become good and Noble all these are in my opinion nothing with sterile exercises and
53:07 | logic yes that's all there is to it men love abstract reasoning and need
53:13 | systemization so much they think there at nothing of distorting the truth closing their eyes and ears to contrary evidence to preserve their logical
53:20 | constructions here's an example you know as mankind becomes more enlightened they should become less bloodthirsty
53:27 | more civilized um now this is before World War I where a lot of European
53:32 | intellectuals and said oh my go there was something wrong with that idea um Doki says you only have to look around
53:40 | you and you see blood being spilled in the most playful way just as if it were champagne look at the United States that
53:46 | indisoluble Union plunged into Civil War the most bloody war in our history yet still um and the most brutal war that
53:54 | we've ever been involved in um what is it then it's mellowed by
53:59 | civilization all it does I'd say is to develop a Mana capacity to feel a greater variety of sensation nothing
54:06 | nothing else um and through this development man will learn how to enjoy
54:13 | Bloodshed that leads us to the third problem right what if the interest what if our genuine interests are bad
54:20 | things um he also talks about reason as well he says I admit reason is a good
54:25 | thing no argument about that but reason is only reason and it only satisfies
54:31 | man's rational requirements desire on the other hand is the manifestation of life itself of all of life and it
54:38 | encompasses everything from reason down to scratching oneself although when we're Guided by our desires life may
54:44 | turn into a messy Affair it's still life and not a series of extractions of square
54:49 | roots I for instance instinctively want to live to exercise all the aspects of life in me and not only reason which
54:56 | amounts to maybe only 12 12th of the whole he also says um what does reason
55:03 | know it only knows what it is learned is that everything no
55:09 | so how do we actually know we're doing things exclusively out of self-interests is that just sort of a a
55:16 | logical construction involved um in theories that want to rationalize
55:22 | everything they just roll everything into self-interest and sort of assume that it's there somewhere um desire if
55:31 | it wants to can agree with reason especially if one uses sparingly never going too far then desire is quite
55:37 | useful even praiseworthy but really in reality desire usually
55:43 | stubbornly disagrees with reason and let me tell you that this is also useful and praiseworthy he
55:52 | says um what about the scale how do we actually
55:57 | measure um the interest of the human being how do you define what's in the interest of a human being he says
56:03 | interest what interest can you define exactly what is in the interest of a human being and
56:09 | suppose the interest of a man is not only consistent with but even demand something
56:18 | harmful um is there an accurate scale of human
56:23 | advantages aren't there any advantages that are that cannot possibly be included in such a scale and as as far
56:30 | as I can understand this is another point he's making you've based your formulas uh you've based

your scale of
56:38 | advantages on statistical averages and scientific formulas thought up by economists and since your scale consists
56:44 | of such advantages as happiness Prosperity Freedom security and all that a man who dis deliberately disregarded
56:50 | that scale will be branded by you as an obscurantist and utterly insane what's really remarkable
56:56 | is that all your statisticians sages and humanitarians when listing human advantages insist on leaving out one of
57:03 | them they never even allow for it thus invalidating all their calculations what
57:08 | advantage is that well that's when we get to this what if the interest of a human
57:14 | being actually were to have their own way even if it's damaging to them even
57:19 | if it's destructive um he sees he says um
57:29 | perhaps there's something that every man values above the highest individual advantage or there may exist a human
57:35 | advantage that is the most advantageous which is also more important than the others and for the
57:41 | sake of which a man if need be will go against reason honor security and prosperity and short against all the
57:47 | beautiful and useful things what is it says it's not it's not just a question
57:52 | of words before I name the this advantage you know let me go on and and
57:57 | and say that these other things don't fit what is it um man will give up airing of his own
58:05 | free will and stop opposing his will to to his interests what is in his interests later on he says one's own
58:14 | free unrestrained choice one's own whim be it the wildest one's own fancy
58:20 | sometimes worked up to a frenzy that is the most advantageous advantage that cannot be be fitted into any table or
58:27 | scale and that causes every system and every Theory to crumble into dust on
58:33 | contact so all of this is undone
58:40 | by wi wanting to do things your own way
58:46 | wanting to be what you want to be even if it doesn't make sense even if it doesn't ultimately bring security
58:52 | Prosperity honor happiness even if it goes against these things one can say
58:58 | no to what's being offered to you this is the Crystal Palace the
59:04 | enlightenment that's where we're going to actually leave off with this this this image that he has of the Crystal
59:09 | Palace created by the men of science where everything is light and truth and
59:16 | Harmony and everything fits together he says um
59:27 | um you know you want to cure human beings of all of their problems you want
59:32 | to lead us through engineering and science to this this Crystal Palace in
59:38 | which everything will fit and I'm going to stick my tongue out at it and I want
59:44 | to be able to stick my tongue out at it and I don't want a place which will turn me into an auton automaton where I
59:51 | wouldn't even think of sticking my tongue out in as he says what I'm for is wh and I want the right to use it
59:58 | whenever I want to I know for example that suffering is inadmissible in light
1:00:03 | stage plays in the utopian Crystal Palace it would be inconceivable for suffering means doubt and denial and
1:00:09 | what kind of Crystal Palace would that be if people had doubts about it nevertheless I'm certain that man will
1:00:14 | never give up true suffering that is chaos and destruction I know that he likes it and
1:00:21 | won't exchange it for any advantage so
1:00:26 | again very typical um existentialist uh piece in many respects
1:00:33 | we've gotten ourselves to the point where we see that at least for the underground man and the the portrait of
1:00:38 | human beings that's being presented it's not saying the enlightenment isn't there it's not saying

these things aren't advantageous it's saying this can't be
1:00:46 | brought within the scope of your system and this is important this is part of the essence of humanity um but how do
1:00:53 | you nail down wom could you come up with catalog of them it wouldn't be whim then would it it would go back into this
1:01:00 | Enlightenment you know timetable schedule sort of thing so that's where we'll leave off and yet another
1:01:06 | important existential uh piece of literature by Fyodor Dostoevsky